

PASSWITHPURPOSE

NEW
2027
FORMAT

CAMBRIDGE IGCSE • FIRST LANGUAGE ENGLISH • 0500

Language Analysis Workbook

Step-by-step practice for the Paper 1 Question 3 language task (200–250 words, 10 marks): six original extracts, a guided method and model answers for every one.

- ◆ 6 original extracts
- ◆ Choose → Zoom → Connect tables
- ◆ 6 model answers
- ◆ Effect phrase bank
- ◆ 3 guided, 3 independent
- ◆ Worked example for each
- ◆ Six mistakes that cost marks
- ◆ Marking bands & tracker

Marcé van Moerkerken

PGCE Secondary English (Summa Cum Laude)
International school English teacher, UAE

For exams in 2027, 2028 and 2029. Independent practice material; not produced or endorsed by Cambridge University Press & Assessment. All extracts are original.

How to use this workbook

In Paper 1 Question 3, students analyse how a writer uses language in two named paragraphs of Text C, in about 200–250 words, for 10 marks. The skill improves quickly with focused, repeated practice. This workbook provides it.

The method: Choose → Zoom → Connect

Choose	Pick three or four short, powerful choices from each paragraph: single words and short phrases work best.
Zoom	Explain the literal meaning, then the connotations: the feelings and images the words carry.
Connect	Explain the effect on the reader: what picture or mood is created, and why the writer wants it.

The route through the book

Extracts 1–3	Guided. Fill in the Choose → Zoom → Connect table (a worked example is given), then write it up.
Extracts 4–6	Independent. Plan quickly, then write 200–250 words in about 25 minutes, as in the exam.
After each one	Compare with the model answer. Highlight one explanation in the model that is better than yours, and rewrite one of your own sentences in the same way.

Phrases for explaining effect

- “...suggests that...”
- “...carries connotations of...”
- “...implies...”
- “...personifies... as...”
- “...so the reader feels...”
- “...emphasising how...”
- “...creating a sense of...”
- “...contrasts with..., highlighting...”

Six mistakes that cost marks

Mistake	Weak	Strong
Feature-spotting	The writer uses personification and a simile.	"The clock... ticked with maddening slowness, each second dragging its feet" personifies time as reluctant, making the wait feel cruel.
"Vivid imagery"	This creates vivid imagery and makes the reader want to read on.	"Ash drifted down like dirty snow" twists something beautiful into something polluted, showing how the fire spoils everything.
Quoting too much	"The storm came in from the sea at dusk, dragging a curtain of black cloud across the harbour."	"dragging" suggests the cloud is hauled over the city like a heavy curtain.
Retelling the story	The family packs quickly and drives away while the fire gets closer.	The rapid verbs "snatched", "flung" and "clutched" convey desperation rather than careful packing.
Ignoring one paragraph	Five choices from paragraph 1, one from paragraph 2.	Three or four choices from each paragraph named in the question.
No overall effect	Ending on a single word choice.	"Overall, the writer creates a sense of energy and release as the storm breaks the city's stifling calm."

THE GOLDEN RULE: Every choice needs three things: the **words** (short quotation), the **meaning or connotation**, and the **effect** on the reader. The marks come from the explanation.

Rain Over the City

- 1 The storm came in from the sea at dusk, dragging a curtain of black cloud across the harbour. The first drops were fat and heavy, smacking into the dust like thrown coins. Then the sky split open. Rain hammered the rooftops, drummed on car bonnets and turned the gutters into brown, gurgling rivers that swallowed litter and leaves in a single gulp.
- 2 The city, which had been sweltering and sluggish all afternoon, jolted awake. Shopkeepers scrambled to drag their displays inside. Pedestrians scattered like startled pigeons, newspapers held uselessly over their heads. Only the children were delighted: they leapt from puddle to puddle, shrieking, faces tilted to the sky as if the rain were a gift that had been promised to them for months.

Task [10 marks]: Re-read the extract. Explain how the writer uses language to convey **the arrival of the storm** in paragraph 1 and **the city's reaction to the rain** in paragraph 2. Select three or four powerful words or phrases from each paragraph. Write about **200 to 250 words**.

Step 1: Choose → Zoom → Connect

	Choice (1–4 words)	Literal meaning	Connotations	Effect on the reader
Example	“dragging”	pulling with effort	heavy, slow, forceful; a curtain being closed	darkness is forced over the city – ominous, like the end of a performance
Paragraph 1				
Paragraph 1				
Paragraph 1				
Paragraph 2				
Paragraph 2				
Paragraph 2				

Step 2: Turn your table into two paragraphs, one per paragraph of the extract, and finish with one sentence on the overall effect.

The Fire on the Ridge

- 1 At first it was only a smudge on the horizon, a grey thumbprint against the blue. By noon the smudge had become a wall. Smoke rolled down the valley in slow, choking waves, and behind it the ridge glowed an angry orange, as though the mountain itself were bleeding. Ash drifted down like dirty snow, settling on the washing line, the windscreen, the back of my hand.
- 2 We did not pack so much as grab. Mum snatched the photo albums from the shelf; Dad flung water bottles into the boot; my sister clutched the cat, which yowled and clawed at her arms. Nobody spoke. The road out of the village was a single slow snake of headlights, crawling through the smoke, and every time I looked back the orange glow had crept a little closer, patient and hungry.

Task [10 marks]: Re-read the extract. Explain how the writer uses language to convey **the approach of the fire** in paragraph 1 and **the family's escape** in paragraph 2. Select three or four powerful words or phrases from each paragraph. Write about **200 to 250 words**.

Step 1: Choose → Zoom → Connect

	Choice (1–4 words)	Literal meaning	Connotations	Effect on the reader
Example	"a wall"	a solid, upright barrier	huge, impassable, blocking escape	the fire now seems overwhelming and trapping – a shocking change from "a smudge"
Paragraph 1				
Paragraph 1				
Paragraph 1				
Paragraph 2				
Paragraph 2				
Paragraph 2				

Step 2: Turn your table into two paragraphs, one per paragraph of the extract, and finish with one sentence on the overall effect.

Mrs Farah's Shop

- 1 Mrs Farah's shop was barely wider than a corridor, but it seemed to contain the whole world. Shelves climbed to the ceiling, crammed with jars of pickles, tins of sardines, spools of thread, torch batteries and faded packets of seeds. The air was thick with the smells of cardamom, soap and old paper. A single bulb swung above the counter, and in its warm, trembling light everything seemed slightly magical, as if the shop had been assembled by a collector of lost things.
- 2 Mrs Farah herself sat behind the counter like a small, watchful owl. Her glasses were perched at the very tip of her nose, and her eyes, sharp and black, missed nothing: the child hovering near the sweets, the young man counting his coins twice. She rarely smiled, but when she did, her whole face creased into a map of kindness, and she would slip an extra orange into your bag without a word.

Task [10 marks]: Re-read the extract. Explain how the writer uses language to convey **the shop** in paragraph 1 and **Mrs Farah** in paragraph 2. Select three or four powerful words or phrases from each paragraph. Write about **200 to 250 words**.

Step 1: Choose → Zoom → Connect

	Choice (1–4 words)	Literal meaning	Connotations	Effect on the reader
Example	"crammed"	packed tightly	overflowing, cluttered, abundant	the shop feels bursting with life and variety despite its tiny size
Paragraph 1				
Paragraph 1				
Paragraph 1				
Paragraph 2				
Paragraph 2				
Paragraph 2				

Step 2: Turn your table into two paragraphs, one per paragraph of the extract, and finish with one sentence on the overall effect.

Sandstorm

- 1 The sky to the west turned the colour of weak tea, then of rust. A low, rolling cliff of sand advanced across the desert, swallowing the dunes one by one, so tall that it seemed to lean over us. The wind arrived first, snapping at our clothes, flinging grit into our eyes and mouths, hissing through the scrub like a thousand angry snakes.
- 2 We sat in the car with the windows sealed and watched the world vanish. Within seconds the road, the palm trees and the petrol station had been erased, replaced by a roaring, rushing orange nothing. Sand scoured the paintwork and ticked against the glass. My father gripped the steering wheel, although we were not moving, as if holding on to it might hold on to the world.

Task [10 marks]: Re-read the extract. Explain how the writer uses language to convey **the approach of the sandstorm** in paragraph 1 and **the experience inside the car** in paragraph 2. Select three or four powerful words or phrases from each paragraph. Write about **200 to 250 words**.

Continue on lined paper. Aim for 3–4 choices per paragraph and an overall-effect sentence.

The Penalty

- 1 The stadium held its breath. Forty thousand people, who had been roaring for ninety minutes, fell so silent that you could hear the flags snapping in the wind. Amira placed the ball on the spot with trembling care, as if it were made of glass. The goalkeeper bounced on her line, arms spread wide, filling the goal like a giant.
- 2 Then the net bulged, and the silence shattered. The noise was not a cheer but an explosion, a great wave of sound that crashed down from the stands and seemed to lift the whole stadium off its foundations. Strangers hugged strangers. An old man wept openly into his scarf. And in the middle of it all, Amira stood perfectly still, her hands over her mouth, as though she could not believe what her own feet had done.

Task [10 marks]: Re-read the extract. Explain how the writer uses language to convey **the tension before the penalty** in paragraph 1 and **the reaction after the goal** in paragraph 2. Select three or four powerful words or phrases from each paragraph. Write about **200 to 250 words**.

Continue on lined paper. Aim for 3–4 choices per paragraph and an overall-effect sentence.

The Waiting Room

- 1 The hospital waiting room was painted a pale, hopeful green that nobody felt. Plastic chairs were bolted to the floor in rows, and on them people sat hunched and silent, clutching paper cups of cold tea. A television in the corner murmured cheerfully to no one. The clock above the door ticked with maddening slowness, each second dragging its feet.
- 2 When the doors finally swung open and the doctor stepped through, every head turned at once, like flowers following the sun. She looked around the room, and for a moment the whole world narrowed to her face. Then she smiled – a small, tired smile – and said our name, and my mother let out a breath she seemed to have been holding for hours.

Task [10 marks]: Re-read the extract. Explain how the writer uses language to convey **the waiting room** in paragraph 1 and **the moment the doctor appears** in paragraph 2. Select three or four powerful words or phrases from each paragraph. Write about **200 to 250 words**.

Continue on lined paper. Aim for 3–4 choices per paragraph and an overall-effect sentence.

Model answers · Extracts 1–2

Extract 1: Rain Over the City 208 words

In the first paragraph, the writer presents the storm as a powerful, almost violent force. The verb “dragging” suggests the cloud is hauled across the harbour like a heavy curtain, implying that darkness is being drawn over the city, as at the end of a performance. The first drops are “smacking into the dust like thrown coins”: “smacking” is harsh and physical, and the simile makes each drop seem solid and deliberate. “The sky split open” is short and dramatic, suggesting a sudden rupture, while “hammered” and “drummed” create relentless, percussive noise. Finally, the gutters become rivers that “swallowed litter and leaves in a single gulp”, personifying the water as a hungry creature and emphasising its speed and force.

In the second paragraph, the city’s reaction shifts from lethargy to panic. “Jolted awake” suggests a sudden shock, contrasting sharply with “sluggish”. People “scrambled” and “scattered like startled pigeons”, verbs that convey hurried, undignified movement, while “uselessly” adds gentle humour to their helplessness. The children, by contrast, are “delighted” and “shrieking” with joy, and the simile of the rain “as if... a gift” shows how welcome it is after the heat. Overall, the writer creates a sense of energy and release as the storm breaks the city’s stifling calm.

Extract 2: The Fire on the Ridge 204 words

In the first paragraph, the writer shows the fire growing from something small into something overwhelming. It begins as “a smudge” and “a grey thumbprint”, images of a tiny mark that seem harmless, but “By noon the smudge had become a wall”: the short sentence and blunt metaphor suggest something solid, huge and impassable. Smoke “rolled down the valley in slow, choking waves”, presenting it as an unstoppable tide, while “choking” reminds us of its danger to life. The ridge “glowed an angry orange, as though the mountain itself were bleeding”, personifying the landscape as wounded and furious. Ash drifting “like dirty snow” twists something beautiful into something polluted, and the list “the washing line, the windscreen, the back of my hand” moves ever closer to the narrator, showing the fire invading their personal space.

In the second paragraph, the family’s panic is conveyed through rapid verbs: “grab”, “snatched”, “flung”, “clutched”. These suggest haste and desperation rather than careful packing. “Nobody spoke” is stark, implying fear too great for words. The traffic becomes “a single slow snake of headlights”, a sibilant image of painful slowness, while the glow “crept a little closer, patient and hungry”, personifying the fire as a predator stalking its prey.

Model answers · Extracts 3–4

Extract 3: Mrs Farah's Shop 210 words

In the first paragraph, the writer presents the shop as small but overflowing with life. “Barely wider than a corridor” stresses its narrowness, yet it “seemed to contain the whole world”, a hyperbole that conveys a sense of wonder. The shelves “climbed to the ceiling, crammed with” goods: “climbed” makes them seem to grow, and “crammed” suggests abundance and clutter. The list – “pickles, tins of sardines, spools of thread, torch batteries and faded packets of seeds” – mixes unrelated items, conveying delightful variety. The smells of “cardamom, soap and old paper” suggest age and familiarity. The “warm, trembling light” of a single bulb creates a cosy, fragile atmosphere, and the “collector of lost things” makes the shop feel magical and nostalgic.

In the second paragraph, Mrs Farah is presented as sharp but secretly kind. The simile “like a small, watchful owl” suggests wisdom and alertness, and her eyes, “sharp and black”, “missed nothing”. The examples of the hovering child and the young man “counting his coins twice” show that she notices people’s needs. Her rare smile turns her face into “a map of kindness”, a metaphor suggesting a lifetime of generosity written on her face, confirmed by the extra orange slipped in “without a word” – kindness without fuss.

Extract 4: Sandstorm 204 words

In the first paragraph, the writer conveys the sandstorm’s immense power. The sky changes from “weak tea” to “rust”, a progression that suggests something draining and decaying, as if the day is being corroded. The storm is “a low, rolling cliff of sand”, a metaphor that makes it seem solid, towering and unstoppable, and “swallowing the dunes” personifies it as a monster devouring the landscape. That it “seemed to lean over us” conveys menace and vulnerability. The wind’s actions – “snapping”, “flinging”, “hissing” – are aggressive verbs, and the simile “like a thousand angry snakes” combines sibilance with an image of countless hostile creatures, making the wind feel alive and dangerous.

In the second paragraph, the storm erases the world. “Watched the world vanish” and “erased” suggest familiar landmarks wiped away like writing on a board. “A roaring, rushing orange nothing” is a striking paradox: the storm is full of noise and movement, yet it leaves only emptiness. “Scoured” and “ticked” contrast violent abrasion with small, relentless sounds. Finally, the father “gripped the steering wheel, although we were not moving”, an irrational gesture that reveals fear and a desperate need for control, “as if holding on to it might hold on to the world”.

Model answers · Extracts 5–6

Extract 5: The Penalty *216 words*

In the first paragraph, the writer creates intense tension. “The stadium held its breath” personifies the crowd as a single body frozen with suspense. The contrast between “roaring for ninety minutes” and a silence so deep “you could hear the flags snapping” emphasises how sudden and complete the hush is. Amira places the ball “with trembling care, as if it were made of glass”, a simile that conveys her nerves and the fragility of the moment, as though one mistake could shatter everything. The goalkeeper “filling the goal like a giant” exaggerates her size, showing how impossible the task feels.

In the second paragraph, the release of tension is explosive. “The silence shattered” links back to the glass image, now broken in triumph. The noise is “not a cheer but an explosion”, a correction that intensifies it, and “a great wave of sound that crashed down” presents the celebration as an overwhelming natural force. The hyperbole that it “seemed to lift the whole stadium off its foundations” suggests unstoppable joy. Emotion spreads: “Strangers hugged strangers” and an old man “wept openly”. Yet Amira “stood perfectly still”, a powerful contrast that shows her shock and disbelief at her own achievement. Overall, the writer builds suspense slowly, then releases it in a single burst of sound and feeling.

Extract 6: The Waiting Room *205 words*

In the first paragraph, the writer conveys the anxiety and tedium of waiting. The walls are “a pale, hopeful green that nobody felt”, an ironic detail: the colour is meant to comfort, but “nobody felt” shows that hope is missing. Chairs “bolted to the floor in rows” suggest rigidity, as if people are trapped. They sit “hunched and silent”, body language that suggests worry, clutching “cold tea” – a small detail showing how long they have waited. The television “murmured cheerfully to no one”, personification that highlights its false cheer, and the clock’s “maddening slowness”, with each second “dragging its feet”, makes time itself seem reluctant and cruel.

In the second paragraph, tension peaks and is released. “Every head turned at once, like flowers following the sun” conveys how completely everyone depends on the doctor for hope. “The whole world narrowed to her face” shows the narrator’s intense focus. The smile is “small, tired”, a restrained, realistic detail that makes the good news believable. Finally, the mother lets out “a breath she seemed to have been holding for hours”, conveying enormous relief, as if the family can finally live again. Overall, the writer moves the reader from stillness and dread to a sudden, fragile hope.

Marking guidance & tracker

Bands written for this workbook to support consistent practice marking; not official Cambridge descriptors.

9–10	A wide range of precise selections from both paragraphs; detailed, perceptive explanation of meaning and effect, including connotations; links to the writer's overall purpose.
7–8	A good range of relevant choices; clear explanations of connotations and effects, several developed.
5–6	Some appropriate choices; explanations generally accurate but sometimes general or uneven between paragraphs.
3–4	Limited selection; some meanings explained; effects vague, or mainly technique labels.
1–2	Few choices; largely repeats the text or labels devices with no explanation.

My progress

Extract	Mark /10	Choices P1	Choices P2	One thing to improve
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				
6				

NEXT STEP

Put the skill into a full paper

The **Paper 1 Practice Packs 1 & 2** include a full language task in each of six practice papers, with indicative content for every paragraph. The **Complete Exam Guide** explains the method for every other question on both papers.

Search **PassWithPurpose** on Teachers Pay Teachers.

ENJOYED THIS WORKBOOK? A short review on TPT helps other teachers find it.

© 2026 Marcé van Moerkerken · PassWithPurpose. Licensed for use by one teacher/classroom (including copies for each student) or one student. Not produced, endorsed or approved by Cambridge University Press & Assessment. All extracts are original.